

FINAL COUNTDOWN
Left, the SpaceX Falcon 9 rocket with the Crew Dragon spacecraft lifts off from Cape Canaveral, Florida, Jun. 25; Shubhanshu with Ax-4 Mission commander Peggy Whitson before the launch

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EXCLUSIVE INTERVIEW

"SPACE WAS SO MUCH FUN, I DIDN'T WANT TO COME BACK"

Let's start from the moment you were in the Falcon-9, ready for lift-off, sitting atop 400 tonnes of rocket fuel—a live bomb if things go wrong. Did you feel any fear?
What we are doing inherently involves risks. To manage them, we have a large team that works on the design, conception, realisation of the rockets and mitigating the risks involved to ensure they are safe enough for people to travel. So, yes, there are risks, but we accept them before we go on a mission.

Q. Was your heart beating faster when you were about to lift off?
No, I was pretty relaxed when the countdown began, because we had just come off the longest unbroken quarantine in the history of human spaceflight. Our mission kept getting delayed for one reason or another. And we ended up staying in quarantine for 32 days compared to the original 14 days. So, I didn't want to go back to the quarantine for sure.